

Title

Protocol for testing a peer-facilitated behaviour intervention to enhance HIV prevention advocacy and reduce stigma among Ugandan PLHIV

Abstract

Background: Community-level HIV prevention remains inadequate in high-prevalence settings. Empowering people living with HIV (PLHIV) to serve as prevention advocates may amplify public health impact beyond individual clinical care. **Methods:** This randomized controlled trial will enrol 210 PLHIV (105 intervention, 105 control) and 599 social network members in Uganda. The intervention arm receives an 8-session peer-facilitated curriculum designed to enhance HIV prevention knowledge, build advocacy self-efficacy, reduce internalized stigma, and facilitate disclosure within social networks. Control participants receive standard care. Assessments occur at baseline, 6, 12, and 18 months. **Primary outcomes:** internalized stigma (measured by validated scale) and self-reported prevention advocacy activities in the 12 months preceding follow-up. **Secondary outcomes:** disclosure patterns among index participants and HIV testing rates and protective behaviours among exposed network members. Proposed sample size of 210 provides 80% power to detect clinically meaningful between-group differences. Analysis will employ mixed-effect models accounting for social network clustering.